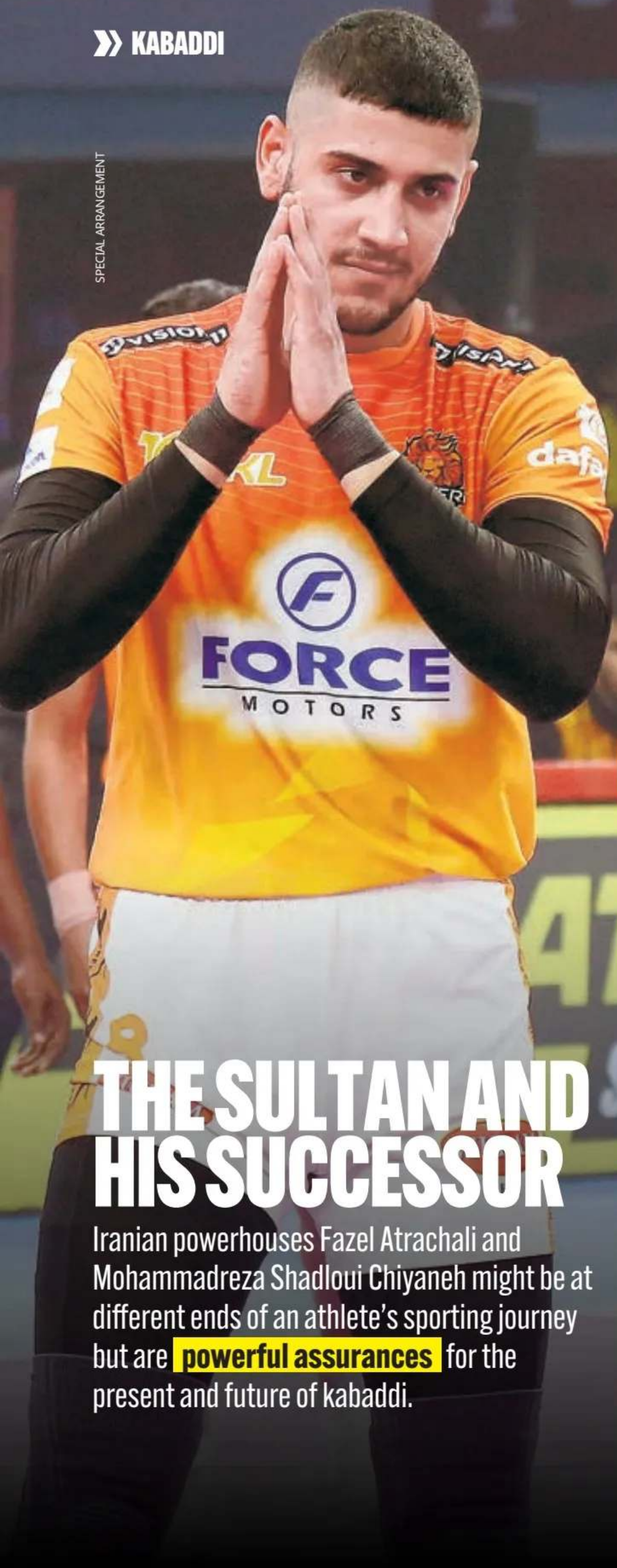




THE SULTAN AND HIS SUCCESSOR

Iranian powerhouses Fazel Atrachali and Mohammadreza Shadloui Chiyaneh might be at different ends of an athlete's sporting journey but are **powerful assurances** for the present and future of kabaddi.

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Team sport is a funny affair. On one side, it is camaraderie and cohesion; on the other, it is also an arena where you can see players striving hard for individual glory. You have opponents to trounce, of course, but you also have your teammates to outshine so you can rise above the rest.

A prime example of this is Iranian all-rounder Mohammadreza Shadloui Chiyaneh (**left**). His individual pursuit of glory in kabaddi has propped up every single team he has turned out for in his nascent career.

Into his third full season in the Pro Kabaddi League (after finishing among the top two defenders in both seasons prior), Shadloui is already among the most feared defenders, flying the Iranian brand of defence-heavy kabaddi high. However, where he steers clear from the rest is in his efforts to not confine his talents to a single department.

"I am a good raider and have the skillset for it. I promise you, if I come into PKL as a pure raider, I will finish somewhere in the top three. But I prefer defence because raiders are injury-prone. If I am required to raid, why not?" the towering Iranian tells *Sportstar*.

A lone wolf

Pro Kabaddi got a glowing example of this last season when he scored 19 points (16 in defence and three raid points) in a close 27-30 loss to Dabang Delhi. That Herculean effort saw him break the league record for most tackle points (16) and most super tackles (eight) in a single match.

"If you have a big heart and your mind and body are ready, you can do anything on the mat. It's all about your mind. I am always ready. Maybe in the next match, I'll score 18 points," Shadloui adds with a smirk. **This confidence from the 23-year-old can often be mistaken for arrogance. However, what sets Shadloui apart is his absolute unabashed acceptance of it.**

"This is my personality. Confidence comes naturally to me. Everyone has a bit of stress before the match or in big tournaments, but when I get onto the mat, my mind focuses on what is happening at that moment," he explains.

After a lull in international action triggered by a lack of consistent efforts from the powers that be and then the COVID-19 pandemic, kabaddi got two major tournaments in 2023 — the Asian Kabaddi Championships in Busan and the Asian Games in Hangzhou.

Iran coach Gholamreza Mazandarani made heads turn when he used Shadloui as a raider in Korea, something that carried into the Asiad in